



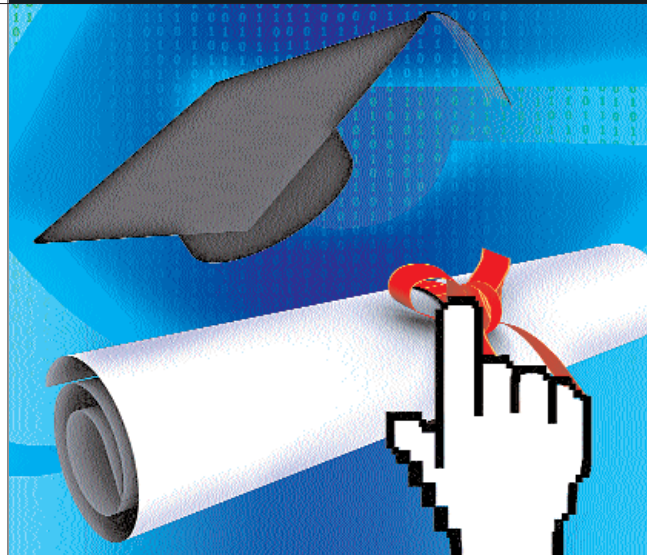
Kaizad Pardiwalla
Vice President
OgilvyOne Worldwide

I think the concept of online education is fantastic. It's a great method to open up education and eliminates the need for people to relocate for their studies and thus brings a whole world of opportunities into the convenience of one's home.

We strongly support and encourage online education in our organisation. A number of employees are currently enrolled in online programmes and we also have many e-learning courses on our intranet.

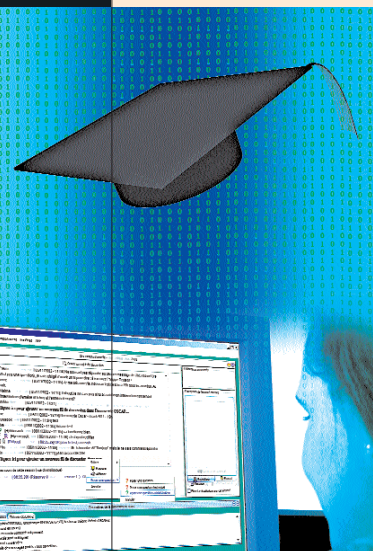
I think that online degrees would be relevant in fields like management, financial services, and as refresher courses for working executives who would not have the time to go to a traditional institute.

As an employer, I would not differentiate between candidates who hold online degrees and those who attended traditional brick-and-mortar institutes. What would matter to me is the person's attitude, experience and capabilities.



ONLINE DEGREE

Do online degrees merit similar status as traditional on-campus programmes?
Digit gets the employers' and placement consultants' take



Gul Raj Bhatia
Country Manager, Marketing
Imaging and Printing Group,
Hewlett-Packard Sales

Online degrees are catching on fast abroad, but are yet to take off in India. I feel that online courses are excellent for offbeat or niche areas of study where fewer students enrol. In a traditional institute, courses are held provided there's a minimum batch size—there is no such restriction online. It's still time before professional qualifications obtained online find acceptance, but supplementary and post-graduate degrees are gaining ground.

For employers, judging the quality of an online programme would be easier in fields like IT, Math etc. where the stress is on mathematical and analytical abilities. For subjective fields like Management or Arts, it would be difficult to pin it down and one would then need to look at the quality of teaching; and this is where I think that having a traditional degree might be more desirable. All things remaining constant, prospective employers wouldn't have issues with a candidate with an online degree—the potential and promise the candidate shows would take precedence.



Saurabh Kanwar
National Head, Marketing
Radio City

The basic concept of online education has been around for a long time, in the form of distance education. The former is a more convenient way to deliver the same knowledge. Distance education is suitable only for some degrees. For instance, it's fine with technical education as opposed to an MBA, which requires a face-to-face interaction and team work as part of the learning process.

Personally, without sounding like a luddite, I'd like to sample the actual knowledge dissemination process for online education, before passing judgement. What a student gains from any education depends very strongly on the quality of the pedagogy, as well as the motivation of the student. That would apply to online education too, and perhaps more so, with the reduced face-to-face interaction and supervision, and the need for a self-driven schedule at times.

As technology and bandwidth progress, we have access to richer and better content on the Web. That will surely have a positive impact on online education in the future.